

Retrofitting a commercial RF induction generator into a computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated annealing system for reactive-metal grain growth

HardwareX manuscript draft

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Status: working draft generated from the repository’s design files, standard operating procedure, parts list, schematics, and run logs. Bracketed [TODO] markers flag values or figures that still need to be confirmed or added before submission. The reproducible build and bill of materials are anchored on the lab’s **current, USA-sourced induction generator** (CEIA “Power Cube” 6 kW, procured through East Coast Induction); the ~1970 LEPEL furnace is documented only as the originating prototype.

An independent review of this draft against the HardwareX section requirements, and the resulting action checklist, are recorded in [edison-feedback/](#); its highest-priority items have been folded into the BOM, specifications table, and the plan’s gap checklist.

Specifications table

Property	Value
Hardware name	Computer-controlled, vacuum-integrated induction annealing system
Subject area	Materials science; mechanical engineering (thermal processing / grain growth)
Hardware type	Heat-treatment / annealing furnace; vacuum system; instrument control
Closest commercial analog	Vacuum induction annealing furnace (turn-key systems cost \$50k-\$200k+)
Open-source license	[TODO: proposed – CERN-OHL-S v2 for hardware/ design files + MIT for code; add a LICENSE file at the repo root before submission]
Cost of hardware	[TODO: total; retrofit + consumables ≈ \$1–2k on top of the generator]

Property	Value
Source file repository	[TODO: mint a permanent DOI – e.g. Zenodo – for the repository; HardwareX does not accept a bare GitHub URL]
Induction generator (reproducible build)	CEIA “Power Cube” 6 kW solid-state RF generator + Master Controller v3+ (East Coast Induction, USA)
Induction generator (prototype)	LEPEL high-frequency tube furnace (~1970), up to ~35 kW
Power-control input	Analog setpoint via LabVIEW/DAQ → current-loop conditioner (4–20 mA on current controller; 0–5 mA on LEPEL)
Generator-input standard required	External analog power-control input with monotonic command→power response over the usable range
Control signal chain	DAQ analog output (0–5 V) → voltage-to-current (4–20 mA) loop conditioner → generator power-setpoint input; pyrometer analog output → DAQ analog input (scaled to °C)
Max sample temperature	~1400–1500 °C+ (Ni/Fe melting range)
Pyrometer detection range	~800–2500 °C (dual-wavelength ratio); does not report below ~700 °C
Demonstrated soak duration	minutes up to ~40 h (per docs/data_log/ run logs)
Sample / crucible envelope	charge fits inside a 35 mm-ID quartz tube and a machined graphite crucible
Vacuum level	~ 1×10^{-6} to 1×10^{-8} Torr (Edwards T-Station 85 turbo-molecular pump)

Property	Value
Temperature measurement	LumaSense IMPAC ISR 6 dual-wavelength ratio pyrometer (~800–2500 °C)
Chamber	Quartz tube, KF40 optical-window flange, inert-gas vent
Crucible / susceptor	In-house machined graphite (3000 °C grade) crucible-susceptor
Work coil	Water-cooled copper, ~3" tall, 2.5" ID, ~6.5 turns

Hardware in context

High-temperature annealing near a metal's melting point drives controlled **grain growth**, which is central to studying microstructure–property relationships in metals such as nickel and iron. Doing this without oxidizing the sample requires both high temperature (~1400–1500 °C) and high vacuum (or inert atmosphere). Commercial vacuum induction annealing furnaces that meet these requirements are expensive turn-key systems, which puts them out of reach for many academic labs.

This work takes the opposite approach: rather than building or buying a complete furnace, we **retrofit and modernize a bare RF induction generator** into a full annealing system by adding (1) computer power control, (2) closed-loop optical temperature control, (3) a high-vacuum quartz-tube chamber, and (4) a machined graphite crucible/susceptor. The emphasis of the contribution is the **modernization stack itself**, which is deliberately **generator-agnostic**: the same control software, vacuum chamber, pyrometer feedback, crucible, and work-coil geometry transfer from one induction generator to another. The only requirement a reader's generator must satisfy is an **analog power-control input with a monotonic command→power response** over the usable range (e.g. 4–20 mA or 0–5 V / 0–5 mA); near-linearity is convenient but not required, because the pyrometer feedback and PID calibration absorb any nonlinearity. That portability is the reproducible result and is what makes the design reusable by other labs that already own, or can buy, such an induction generator.

A second feature that broadens the system's applicability is the **machined graphite crucible/susceptor**: because graphite couples strongly to the RF field and heats the charge indirectly by

conduction and radiation, the furnace is not limited to electrically conductive samples — it can also process poorly- or non-coupling materials such as YSZ ceramic. This makes the same build useful well beyond reactive-metal annealing.

The modernization was first prototyped on a ~1970 LEPEL high-frequency induction furnace owned by the BYU Mechanical Engineering department — at the time the only departmental machine able to reach the Ni/Fe melting range. A “remote control” capability was added in August 2019 to drive the generator’s power from a computer instead of the front-panel knob. The lab subsequently moved the same stack onto a current, USA-sourced solid-state generator (CEIA “Power Cube” 6 kW via East Coast Induction), whose Master Controller v3+ accepts a standard analog (4-20 mA) power setpoint. An intermediate, separately-purchased import generator (CYSI GP-15A) was evaluated but did not meet the lab’s control requirements — the required analog remote-control input was lost across vendor model substitutions — and was retired. The reproducible build documented here therefore targets the current USA generator, with the LEPEL retrofit retained as historical context.

Compared with commercial vacuum annealing furnaces, this approach has **substantially lower capital cost** (the retrofit and consumables add roughly \$1-2k on top of a generator a lab already owns, versus \$50k-\$200k+ for turn-key systems), is repairable and modifiable by the user, and is broadly reusable: any lab with an induction generator and an analog power input can reproduce the control, vacuum, and temperature-sensing additions described below.

Reproducibility boundary

To be explicit about what this paper does and does not reproduce: **this work does not reproduce the RF generator internals**. It reproduces the *modernization layer* built around a compatible generator — the computer power control, optical (pyrometer) feedback, high-vacuum quartz-tube chamber, machined graphite crucible/susceptor, work-coil geometry, and the mechanical support fixturing. A reader supplies (or already owns) a compatible generator and rebuilds the layer described here.

Prior art and comparison

Class	Examples	Limitation this design addresses
Commercial vacuum induction	turn-key systems	Cost; closed/non-modifiable; vendor lock-in

Class	Examples	Limitation this design addresses
annealing furnaces	(\$50k-\$200k+)	
Open non-induction annealing systems	tube/box furnaces with resistive heating	Lower max temperature and slower ramp than induction; no RF-susceptor heating of non-coupling charges
Induction generators sold bare	CEIA, Ambrell, etc.	Ship without integrated vacuum, optical feedback, or computer setpoint control — exactly the layer added here

Generator compatibility requirements

The control/sensing/vacuum layer transfers to any generator that meets these criteria:

- Exposes an **external analog power-control input** (e.g. 4–20 mA or 0–5 V/0–5 mA).
- The command→delivered-power response is **monotonic over the usable range** (near-linear is convenient but not required, since the pyrometer feedback closes the loop).
- Supports a **water-cooled induction head/coil** matching the documented coil dimensions.
- Delivers **enough RF power** to reach the target temperature for the documented crucible/sample stack.
- Allows **safe electrical isolation** between the DAQ/control path and the generator input.
- Has the required cooling and line power for the selected generator.

When porting to a new generator, the following must be re-established: analog-command scaling, power-to-temperature calibration, PID gains, coil/sample alignment, maximum safe ramp rate, and any generator-specific interlock behavior.

Transferability: LEPEL prototype → CEIA reproducible build

Aspect	LEPEL prototype (~1970)	CEIA reproducible build (current)	Transferred?
Analog control interface	0–5 mA	4–20 mA (Master Controller v3+)	Concept yes; scaling re-set

Aspect	LEPEL prototype (~1970)	CEIA reproducible build (current)	Transferred?
Frequency	~200–450 kHz tube	solid-state (generator-set)	n/a (generator internal)
Max power	up to ~35 kW	6 kW	Re-tuned for charge
Pyrometer / optical feedback	dual- wavelength	same dual- wavelength stack	Yes
Vacuum chamber / quartz tube	quartz + KF40	same	Yes
Graphite crucible/ susceptor	machined graphite	same	Yes
Support stand / fixturing	bolted stand	same	Yes
LabVIEW/ DAQ control concept	manual + ramp/PID VIs	same VIs	Yes

Hardware description

The system comprises five subsystems (see the schematics in [extracted-context/schematic_induction_furnace.md](#) and [extracted-context/schematic_support_stand.md](#)):

1. **RF generator + work coil.** A solid-state induction generator (current build: CEIA Power Cube 6 kW) drives a water-cooled copper work coil. The coil carries both the oscillating current and cooling water. Coil geometry (~3" tall, 2.5" ID, ~6.5 turns) was tuned to the sample/crucible stack (see [extracted-context/order_corrections_coils.md](#)).
2. **Vacuum + gas.** A quartz tube forms the chamber and is connected through a KF40 flange and flexible bellows to an Edwards T-Station 85 turbo-molecular pump ($\sim 1 \times 10^{-6}$ – 10^{-8} Torr). A manual vent valve and an inert-gas regulator allow controlled venting/backfilling to suppress oxidation of reactive metals. The vacuum connection stack, in order, is: **quartz tube → KF40 flange + optical window → flexible bellows → vacuum gauge → Edwards T-Station 85 → vent / inert-gas backfill branch.**

3. **Optical temperature sensing.** A dual-wavelength (ratio) pyrometer (the canonical unit is a LumaSense IMPAC ISR 6, 800–2500 °C; the IMPAC brand is LumaSense's) views the sample through a KF40 optical window, providing a non-contact temperature signal that is robust to emissivity changes and to the RF field that would corrupt thermocouples.
4. **Control / DAQ + LabVIEW.** A LabVIEW DAQ analog output sets generator power; the pyrometer signal is read back for closed-loop ramp/soak control. The VIs implement manual control, automated ramping, PID tuning, and email alerts (see [../code/](#)). In the CEIA build the DAQ outputs **0–5 V** to a **voltage-to-current loop conditioner** that converts the command to the controller's **4–20 mA** power-setpoint input (the LEPEL prototype instead took a 0–5 mA command directly). The closed-loop **signal flow** is therefore: **LabVIEW setpoint → DAQ analog output (0–5 V) → V→I conditioner (4–20 mA) → generator power → sample/crucible heating → pyrometer optical reading → DAQ analog input (scaled to °C) → PID controller → updated analog command**. The same path runs **open-loop** (direct command ramp) while the temperature is below the pyrometer's ~700 °C detection floor; once the pyrometer reports a **sustained valid reading above that floor**, control hands over to **closed-loop** PID on the optical temperature.
5. **Mechanical support stand + crucible.** A bolted support stand (8 short + 4 long sections, 12 corner braces, 4 floor mounts) positions the chamber, coil, pyrometer holder, and quartz disc. An **in-house machined graphite crucible** holds the sample and acts as the RF susceptor.

Custom-machined graphite crucible / susceptor

Because some charges of interest couple poorly to the RF field (e.g. YSZ ceramic) or must be physically contained, the sample is held in a **graphite crucible machined in-house from 3000 °C-grade graphite stock** (Cotronics 56L-3). The graphite couples strongly to the induction field and acts as a **susceptor**, transferring heat to the contained charge by conduction/radiation; this makes the same furnace usable for conductive metals (direct coupling) and for non/poorly-coupling materials (indirect, susceptor-driven heating). Crucibles are machined to fit inside the quartz tube and seat on a ceramic-cylinder / Teflon spacer stack. Cracked crucibles are repaired with a 3000 °C graphite cement (Resbond 931) rather than discarded. [TODO: add the crucible machining drawing and photos to paper/figures/.]

Who can use this system

- Materials labs needing **oxidation-free grain-growth anneals** of reactive metals (Ni, Fe) near their melting points.
- Labs that own a **bare induction generator** and want to add computer setpoint control, optical feedback, and vacuum integration without buying a turn-key furnace.
- Groups processing **poorly- or non-coupling charges** (e.g. YSZ ceramic) that can be heated indirectly through the graphite susceptor.
- Teaching/maker contexts wanting a **repairable, modifiable** high-temperature vacuum furnace built from documented, open design files.

Design files summary

Design file	File type	Open source license	Location of the file
LabVIEW control VIs (furnace control, manual control, PID tuning v1/v2, email alert)	LabVIEW.vi	MIT (proposed)	../code/induction-furnace-control-code/
Manual ramping v5 VIs	LabVIEW.vi	MIT (proposed)	../code/manual-ramping-v5/
plotheatcurve.m (heat-curve plotter)	MATLAB	MIT (proposed)	../code/plotheatcurve.m
Work-coil drawing	PDF / OXPS	CERN-OHL-S (proposed)	docs/coils-drawing.pdf, docs/coils.oxps
System schematics	PPTX (+ extracted text/figures)	CERN-OHL-S (proposed)	docs/*.pptx, extracted-context/
Temperature-control wiring	PNG	CERN-OHL-S (proposed)	docs/temp-control-modification/0-5V PLC wire design.png
KF40 overpressure centering ring	STEP	CERN-OHL-S (proposed)	docs/KF Supplies/ KF40_overpressureCenteringRing.step

Design file	File type	Open source license	Location of the file
Graphite crucible/susceptor machining drawing	[TODO: add]	CERN-OHL-S (proposed)	[TODO]

[TODO: export the LabVIEW .vi block diagrams to PDF/PNG so non-LabVIEW readers can inspect the control logic.]

Bill of materials summary

HardwareX requires a single 7-column BOM table. Groupings are denoted by the designator prefix: **GEN** = induction generator + controller (the current USA reproducible build; the legacy LEPEL is the prototype alternative, not a line item), **RETRO** = the reproducible retrofit (control / vacuum / sensing) parts, and **CONS** = consumables. Full vendor/price detail for the RETRO and CONS parts is in [extracted-context/parts_list.md](#) (extracted from docs/induction_parts_list.xlsx).

Costing conventions: all costs are in **USD**; prices are the lab's purchase records (quote year ~2019–2021), several from used/surplus/eBay sources as noted; shipping and tax are excluded unless stated. The table below is the **canonical reproducible build only** — legacy LEPEL and the rejected CYSI import path are documented in the text, not the BOM.

Designator	Component	Number	Cost per unit	Total cost	Source of materials	Material type
GEN-1	CEIA “Power Cube” 6 kW solid-state RF generator	1	[TODO]	[TODO]	East Coast Induction (USA)	—
GEN-2	Master Controller v3+	1	[TODO]	[TODO]	East Coast Induction (USA)	—
GEN-3	Recirculating water chiller	1	[TODO]	[TODO]	[TODO]	—
RETRO-1	LabVIEW-compatible DAQ with analog out + in (e.g. NI USB-6001/6009-	1	[TODO]	[TODO]	National Instruments	—

Designator	Component	Number	Cost per unit	Total cost	Source of materials	Material type
	class, 0–5 V AO) [confirm exact model]					
RETRO-2	Dual-wavelength ratio pyrometer (LumaSense IMPAC ISR 6, 800–2500 °C)	1	\$241 (used)	\$241	eBay / OEM	—
RETRO-3	24 V linear power supply for pyrometer (International Power)	1	\$51	\$51	Mouser	—
RETRO-4	Voltage-to-current (0–5 V → 4–20 mA) loop conditioner for the generator power-setpoint input	1	[TODO]	[TODO]	[TODO: signal-conditioning vendor]	—
RETRO-5	Edwards T-Station 85 turbo-molecular pump + gauge	1	[TODO]	[TODO]	Edwards	—
RETRO-6	Edwards TAV5 vent valve	1	\$59	\$59	eBay	—
RETRO-7	Inert-gas regulator (Fisher FS-50)	1	\$38	\$38	Fisher Scientific	—
RETRO-8	KF40 overpressure centering ring	1	\$19	\$19	IdealVac	aluminum
RETRO-9	KF40 plastic quick vacuum clamp	1	\$23	\$23	IdealVac	polymer
RETRO-10	Optical window, quartz disc 55 mm × 1.5 mm (1 used; buy 3 for spares)	3	\$18	\$54	McMaster-Carr (custom)	fused quartz
RETRO-11	Ultra-high-temperature	1	\$19	\$19	McMaster-Carr	fused quartz

Designator	Component	Number	Cost per unit	Total cost	Source of materials	Material type
RETRO-12	quartz disc 2" × 1/16" Inert-gas plumbing (BSPT/KF adapters, barbs, tee, 10 psi relief valve McMaster 4772K4)	1 set	see parts list	~\$66	McMaster-Carr / BMotionTech	brass / steel
CONS-1	Quartz tube, 4' × 35 mm ID, cut to length	2	\$67	\$134	QSI Quartz	fused quartz
CONS-2	Graphite stock for machined crucible/susceptor (56L-3, 3000 °C, 1"×6"×6")	1	\$99	\$99	Cotronics	graphite
CONS-3	Graphite repair cement (Resbond 931-1, 3000 °C)	1	\$108	\$108	Cotronics	graphite
CONS-4	Alumina crucible stock (RTC-60-2, 1787 °C, 10 lb)	1	\$91	\$91	Cotronics	alumina
CONS-5	Zirconia crucible stock (760-1, 2204 °C, 10 lb)	1	\$124	\$124	Cotronics	zirconia
CONS-6	Torr-Seal high-vacuum epoxy / O-rings	1 set	\$57	\$57	Varian / McMaster	epoxy elastomer

[TODO: confirm GEN-1/2/3, RETRO-1/4/5 pricing, the exact NI DAQ model, and the V→I loop-conditioner model; the GEN line items dominate total cost and must be filled from the East Coast Induction quote before submission.]

Build instructions

1. **Support stand.** Assemble the bolted stand (8 short + 4 long sections, 12 corner braces, 4 floor mounts) and mount the generator/heating head and pyrometer holder.
2. **Work coil.** Form/water-cool the copper coil to the corrected geometry (~3" tall, 2.5" ID, ~6.5 turns); connect to the generator head and the cooling-water circuit. Use the before/after figures from `induction_order_corrections.pptx` as the reference. [TODO: state the exact copper-tube OD/wall, bend radius/spacing method, and cooling-connection fittings from the coil drawing (`docs/coils-drawing.pdf`).]
3. **Graphite crucible/susceptor.** Machine the crucible from 3000 °C graphite stock to fit inside the quartz tube and accept the sample. Seat it on the ceramic-cylinder / Teflon spacer stack. Repair any cracks with graphite cement.
4. **Vacuum chamber.** Mount the quartz tube with the KF40 flange and optical window. The **reference build** seats a 55 mm quartz window on the overpressure KF40 centering ring and secures it with the plastic quick-clamp (reusable, no adhesive); a Torr-Seal'd blank flange is documented as an alternative for a permanent seal. Connect the flexible bellows to the Edwards T-Station 85 turbo pump; install the manual vent valve and inert-gas line.
5. **Control wiring.** Wire the DAQ analog output (0-5 V) through the voltage-to-current loop conditioner to the generator's analog power-control input (4-20 mA on the current CEIA controller; the LEPEL prototype took 0-5 mA directly). Wire the pyrometer output into the DAQ analog input and, for closed-loop ramping, the pyrometer/PLC temperature-control path (`docs/temp-control-modification/`). Maintain electrical isolation between the DAQ/control path and the generator interface.
6. **Software.** Deploy the LabVIEW VIs from `../code/` and configure the DAQ channels; verify manual control before enabling automated ramp/soak.

[TODO: curate a clean, photographed build sequence – candidate photos exist in `docs/data_log/.../IFrun036_*` and the PPTX media.]

Operation instructions

Condensed from the lab SOP (`extracted-context/SOP_induction_200901.md`).

Preflight checklist (before energizing RF)

☐

Chamber at high vacuum ($\sim 1 \times 10^{-6}$ Torr or better) or backfilled to the intended inert atmosphere.

☐

Cooling-water flow confirmed at the coil/generator (no leaks).

☐

Coil/sample alignment and chamber clearance verified.

☐

Pyrometer aligned and sighted on the sample/crucible.

☐

No conductive objects (jewelry, watches, phones, tools) within ≥ 6 –12" of the coil.

Startup

1. **Load the sample.** With the chamber vented to atmosphere (never open the vent valve while the turbo pump is spinning), stack sample → optional alumina plate → ceramic cylinder → Teflon spacer inside the graphite crucible, insert into the quartz tube, and clamp the KF40 flange finger-tight with the O-ring.
2. **Pump down.** Close the vent valve, start the roughing/turbo pumps, and wait for high vacuum ($\sim 1 \times 10^{-6}$ Torr or better).
3. **Cooling water.** Open the facility cooling-water valve ($\sim 45^\circ$, half open) and the generator chiller; check for leaks and confirm flow before applying RF power.

Normal run

1. **Power on.** Bring up the generator per its sequence, then run the LabVIEW ramp/soak profile. Below the pyrometer's $\sim 700^\circ\text{C}$ detection floor the VI ramps **open-loop** on the analog command; once the pyrometer returns a **sustained valid reading above the $\sim 700^\circ\text{C}$ floor** (the handoff criterion), control switches to **closed-loop** PID on the optical temperature.
2. **Anneal.** Hold the temperature/time profile (e.g. $\sim 1200^\circ\text{C}$ for several hours for Ni grain growth); the VI can email status alerts.

Shutdown

1. **Ramp down.** Ramp power down and stop RF, then turn off cooling water, allow the sample to cool under vacuum, and vent only after the turbo pump has fully stopped.

Abort / emergency stop

- **Loss of cooling water or chiller alarm:** immediately command power to zero / stop RF, then investigate; do not re-energize until flow is restored.
- **Vacuum loss or quartz-tube fracture:** stop RF immediately; do not vent against a spinning turbo pump.
- **Arcing, smoke, or runaway temperature:** zero the analog command, kill RF at the generator, and lock out before inspecting.

Validation and characterization

The repository contains 100+ logged runs (docs/data_log/, IFrun001-100) across Ni200, Ni4N5, YSZ, and Pd thermal-evaporation experiments, with temperatures of ~900-1400 °C and soak durations from minutes to ~40 h, each with .xlsx/.txt/.lvm traces and some photos. The minimum publishable validation package targets five figures, each with quantitative metrics rather than qualitative claims.

Figure 1 — System overview. A labeled photograph/composite of generator, controller, chiller, coil, quartz chamber, pyrometer line-of-sight, vacuum station, and control computer.

Figure 2 — Power-command → temperature calibration. For a fixed sample/crucible geometry, steady-state temperature at several analog command values spanning the useful range, ideally $n \geq 3$ runs per setpoint reported as mean $\pm$ SD. Plot analog command (mA / scaled %) vs. pyrometer temperature (°C) with between-run error bars; fit a model only if the data justify it, and show the operationally linear region explicitly. Hold coil geometry, crucible, optical alignment, vacuum level, and sample type fixed; state the pyrometer's valid range and calibration assumptions.

Figure 3 — Representative ramp/soak with control error. One representative anneal (e.g. Ni at ~1200 °C) plotting setpoint and measured temperature vs. time, parsed from a data log via

plotheatcurve.m or a Python equivalent. Quantify **rise time, overshoot, settling time, soak mean temperature, soak SD/ RMS error, and maximum absolute deviation during soak.**

Figure 4 — Repeatability across runs. The same programmed profile run ≥ 3 times on the same setup; overlay the traces and report soak mean temperature, between-run SD, coefficient of variation, and any long-soak drift. Use archived runs only if they are truly same-profile/geometry/material/sensor, and state this explicitly.

Figure 5 — Microstructural validation (SEM + EBSD). The furnace exists to change microstructure, so the key validation is **real microstructural data**: SEM micrographs of as-received vs. annealed samples (e.g. Ni200 / Ni4N5) and EBSD inverse-pole-figure and grain-boundary maps for at least one annealed condition. Quantify grain size properly: number of grains analyzed, equivalent-circle-diameter or intercept metric, median + IQR (or mean $\pm$ SD), segmentation/cleanup criteria, minimum-grain-area threshold, and whether twins are merged or separated. Compare as-received vs. annealed descriptively (and statistically only where replicate specimens justify it), and, where multiple runs exist, plot grain size vs. soak temperature/time.

Suggested controls that build reviewer trust: open-loop vs. closed-loop on the same target cycle; vacuum vs. inert-gas backfill mode; directly-coupled metal vs. susceptor-mediated ceramic heating; and long-soak (multi-hour) stability.

Specimen $\leftrightarrow$ thermal-history linkage. Each microstructure specimen will be tied to its exact run via a table:

Specimen	Material	Run ID	Soak T (°C)	Soak time	Atmosphere / vacuum	Cooling mode	Grain size (received $\rightarrow$ annealed)
[TODO]	[TODO]	[TODO]	[TODO]	[TODO]	[TODO]	[TODO]	[TODO]

[TODO: select canonical run IDs from docs/data_log/; add the SEM/EBSD image files (source candidate micrographs from docs/student-work/RyanWeber.pdf) and the parsed thermal traces under paper/figures/.]

Safety

The system combines high voltage/RF, high vacuum, high temperature, and water cooling; the principal hazards and mitigations are summarized below.

Hazard	Failure mode	Consequence	Mitigation
High voltage / RF field	Contact with coil or induced currents in nearby conductors	Electric shock, burns	Keep conductive objects/electronics $\geq 6-12"$ from the coil while powered; isolate DAQ/control path
Lockout-tagout	Internal transformer-tap change (LEPEL prototype)	Shock during service	Follow LOTO before opening the generator
Vacuum / quartz	Venting against a spinning turbo pump; quartz fracture/implosion	Pump destruction; flying glass	Never vent while the turbo spins; handle quartz/gauge carefully; use eye protection
Water + electricity	Coil/chiller leak near energized hardware	Shock, equipment damage	Confirm flow and check for leaks before RF; route water away from electronics
Thermal	Sample melt-through; hot graphite oxidizing on vent	Pump-line contamination, burns	Cool under vacuum; let cool before venting; nitrile gloves when loading/unloading
Inert gas	Backfill/venting in an enclosed space	Asphyxiation	Adequate ventilation; do not backfill in confined areas
EMI	RF coupling into nearby instruments	Data corruption,	Shield/separate sensitive

Hazard	Failure mode	Consequence	Mitigation
		instrument damage	electronics; keep them clear of the coil

PPE / shielding. Operators should wear safety glasses (quartz-fracture/implosion risk), clean nitrile gloves when handling vacuum components, and remove all conductive personal items before approaching the energized coil; keep sensitive instrumentation outside the RF near-field.

Ethics statements

This work did not involve human participants, human data, or animal subjects. There are no associated ethical considerations.

Declarations

- **CRedit author roles:** [TODO: confirm] — provisional: Sterling G. Baird (conceptualization, software, investigation, writing); Kevin Cole (methodology, resources, supervision); additional authors to be confirmed.
- **Acknowledgements:** BYU Mechanical Engineering Department; the Johnson group; Kevin Cole. [TODO: funding sources.]
- **Declaration of competing interests:** [TODO] — provisional: the authors declare no competing interests.
- **Data availability:** design files, logs, and extracted context are in this repository (vertical-cloud-lab/custom-induction-furnace); a permanent DOI will be minted (Zenodo) before submission and listed in the specifications table.

References

[TODO: add the formatted reference list before submission.
 Anticipated citations: (1) a general induction-heating / eddy-current reference (e.g. Davies, *Conduction and Induction Heating*) for the physics of RF coupling and susceptor heating; (2) a grain-growth / recrystallization reference (e.g. Humphreys & Hatherly, *Recrystallization and Related Annealing Phenomena*) motivating the annealing study; (3) a ratio/dual-wavelength pyrometry reference for the non-contact temperature measurement;

(4) the HardwareX author guidelines; and (5) any prior open-source furnace-control hardware papers used for comparison. Confirm exact citations and DOIs.]